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## Explorer's heritage of Antarctica

Google's street view just became more interesting with Google adding 360 degree images of the South Pole and houses used by the early south pole explorers

sound reproduction of the SBX 200 may not be true to source but is certainly pleasing. Mids are slightly enhanced to give it that warm "I can play most genres" appeal. Distortion occurs past the 80 per cent mark. Bass is not tight, notes are not easily distinguishable but it has that thump. The remote matches its plain vanilla stylings but it has some useful buttons - for instance, muting. It gets bonus points for being able to comfortably fit an iPad without blocking any drivers. At 100 and 250 Hz the Onkyo performs better than the more expensive Creative Zisound D5. In fact the SBX 200 is the fourth best performer in the test. The ABX-100 though is very mediocre.

### Chroma iPod T Speaker

This iPod dock comes in the form of a long floorstander. It has a subwoofer at the bottom half with front facing bass vent. Switch it on and you get something that can loosely be described as sound. The buttons are tacky, there isn't any stereo separation, the feet don't screw in properly and there is little in terms of finish on the device. What's it good for then you ask? Belting out loud music. Other than that it has a lot of connectivity option. But in terms of sound reproduction there is a lot left to be desired. Distortion kicks in as soon as the instrument density increases. There is little detail and clarity. The bass performance is not bad, in the sense that there is quantity. At a price tag of ₹9,000 and a street price that's still cheaper, the device bags our best buy award.



Chroma iPod T Speaker

### Creative Zisound D5

The D5 resembles a black monolithic cuboid, winning a red dot award for its minimalistic design. The 30-pin connector jack on the device that goes into your iPod is in fact a bluetooth transmitter. It's small, attaches to your iPod effortlessly and easy to carry around. When docked physically with the iPod, there is no difference in sound quality so we suspect that contacts on the back of the dongle are just for charging and it continues to stream wirelessly even when docked. Despite supporting a codec for high-quality streaming, its performance is lackluster. Upper mids and bass frequencies on our sound sweeps were distorted. There is severe lack of detail as well.

### JBL OnBeat Xtreme

The JBL looks absolutely stunning with its jet black metal grille, cross weave pattern and chromed lining. Besides sporting nice design, the OnBeat Xtreme is brilliant at waking you up. Its thump, clarity will surprise even the biggest sceptics. Certain tones sound really good on the device - string bass, for instance. But strangely vocals lack body. Despite its bass focus, it's not lost out on detail, clarity and sharpness. While the Philips Fidelio DS9000 mellowed down the edge in our metal tracks, this one maintained the hardcore appeal that a prog/death track deserves. The JBL did have issues with certain frequencies

on our sweep but it has several things going for it. Its packed with features such as Bluetooth pairing, iPad docking ability, landscape/portrait capability and at the same time the price tag of ₹24,990 is good value for money. This makes it our Editor's Pick.



JBL OnBeat Xtreme

### Philips Fidelio DS 9000

No other dock could match the thump and volume levels produced by this device. There's only one word to describe the sound produced from this device - "rich". It's the kind of room-filling aural experience one would expect from a device like this. Bass is powerful and deep - the sort that rolls around in the pit of your stomach and is hard hitting as well. Some of our test tracks didn't go down well with this system though. The low notes at the start of Angel left a sort of "burring" in the drivers toward the end of each bass note. The sound is more rounded (full bodied) compared to the Beosound but definitely coloured. The build is excellent, its wood body adds not just acoustic appeal but classy allure too. Its expensive sure, but worth considering if our next contender is out of your budget.

### Bang & Olufsen Beosound 8

As always we save the best for last. The Beosound 8 is in a league of its own. In fact, so far ahead was its performance (and asking price) that we were con-

sidering keeping it in a category unto itself. The Beosound 8 is a monster iPod Dock that produces unmatched clarity and detail. It easily transgresses into audiophile territory and still remains a device for casual use. In our classical bass sample we could hear the shuffling around of the artist. Bass frequencies are played with pristine precision. Crisp precise bass in Angel is a rarity for high-end speakers let alone iPod docks but the Beosound handled it with ease. On our vocal track it managed to maintain that husky edge in Chris Reas voice without producing unnecessary sibilance.

The Beosound looks drop-dead gorgeous. The conical driver units connected by what looks from the front like a pure block of aluminium gives it that otherworldly sense. At the back you have a panel that pops open to reveal the ports - there's no sign of



Bang & Olufsen Beosound 8

a bass port. We popped it open to reveal a large driver and tweeter. Does the performance behemoth have any flaws? If we were to nit-pick the only shortcoming was notices on tracks such as on Pull Me Under by Dream Theater where the double bass hits drift off amongst the heavy riffs and thick instrumentation. But overall the Beosound 8 performed exceptionally well and is our best performer of the test. 